touching experience of all was when a young woman approached me in Mumbai airport, while I was awaiting a flight, and said: ‘Sir, you are an inspiration for people like me because you’ve proved that it is possible for someone from a middle-class, underprivileged background to rise to the top.’

As I conclude this book on my five years at the Reserve Bank, I must acknowledge that I was fortunate to have served in a central bank during a remarkable period. From a central-banking perspective, history will mark that period for two distinct developments. The first is the extraordinary show of policy force with which central banks responded to the global financial crisis. This has generated a vigorous debate on the short-term and long-term implications of unconventional monetary policies, as also on the responsibility of central banks for the cross-border spillover impact of their policies. The second historical marker will be the manner in which, reflecting the lessons of the crisis, the mandate, autonomy and accountability of central banks are being redefined in several countries around the world.

Notwithstanding all the tensions and anxieties of policy management during an admittedly challenging period, I consider myself enormously privileged to have led one of the finest central banks in the world during such an intellectually vigorous period. There were taxing times, testing times, anxious times. But at all times, I moved on with the confidence that there is a great institution behind me that will steer me in the right direction. I was deeply impressed by the professionalism, intellectual agility and commitment of the staff and officers of the Reserve Bank. This is an institution that has served the country with dignity and distinction, and will continue to set exemplary standards for professional integrity and work ethic.

Finally, how would I like to be remembered? As a governor whose every decision and action was motivated by one and only one consideration—the larger public interest; as someone who never swerved from the Reserve Bank’s dharma.